Himaayah Schools
SKILLS SCHOOL

FREE GUIDE

عَلَّمَ الْإِنسَانَ مَا لَمْ يَعْلَمْ

"He taught man what he did not know." (al-ʿAlaq 96:5)

Digital Skills for Beginners

The computer and internet skills every student and young worker needs: files, email, documents, spreadsheets, safety and more.

Before you begin

Schools, universities and employers now expect everyone to use a computer confidently: to type and save a document, send a proper email, build a simple spreadsheet, make a presentation, search well and stay safe online. Many young people are fast on a phone but unsure on a computer. This guide fills that gap, step by step.

You do not need an expensive laptop to start. A shared or second-hand computer, a cybercafé, or a school computer lab is enough to practise most of what is here, and many of the tools are free: Google Docs, Sheets and Slides work in any browser.

> إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ إِذَا عَمِلَ أَحَدُكُمْ عَمَلًا أَنْ يُتْقِنَهُ
>
> **“Allah loves that when one of you does a job, he does it with excellence.”**
>
> Narrated by Abū Yaʿlā and al-Bayhaqī; graded ḥasan by some scholars.

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Part 1 Computer basics

Term	Meaning
Hardware	The physical parts: screen, keyboard, mouse, processor (CPU), memory (RAM), storage (hard disk or SSD).
Software	Programs that run on the computer: the operating system (Windows, macOS, Linux, ChromeOS) and apps (browser, Word, Excel).
RAM and storage	RAM is short-term working memory, emptied when you switch off. Storage keeps your files permanently.
Browser	The app for using the web: Chrome, Edge, Firefox or Safari.
Cloud storage	Saving files on the internet (Google Drive, OneDrive) so you can reach them from any device and do not lose them if your computer breaks.

Files and folders

Most lost work is caused by poor file habits. Follow these rules from day one:

- Keep one main folder for your work, with sub-folders by subject or project: **School › Physics › Practicals**.
- Give files clear names with dates: **Physics-practical-report-2026-10-27.docx**, not **New document (3).docx**.
- Save early and often (**Ctrl + S**). Keep a backup in the cloud or on a flash drive.
- Know where your downloads go (usually the **Downloads** folder), and move files to the right folder straight away.
- Common file types: **.docx** (Word), **.xlsx** (Excel), **.pptx** (PowerPoint), **.pdf** (for sharing and printing, hard to edit), **.jpg/.png** (images), **.zip** (a compressed folder).

Part 2 Typing and shortcuts

Typing properly with all ten fingers, without looking at the keys, is the single most useful computer skill. Aim for **30 words a minute** first, then 40 or more. Free sites such as typing.com and keybr.com let you practise for 15 minutes a day.

Shortcut (Windows)	What it does	Shortcut (Windows)	What it does
Ctrl + C	Copy	Ctrl + Z	Undo
Ctrl + X	Cut	Ctrl + Y	Redo
Ctrl + V	Paste	Ctrl + S	Save
Ctrl + A	Select all	Ctrl + F	Find on the page
Ctrl + P	Print	Ctrl + B / I / U	Bold / italic / underline
Alt + Tab	Switch between windows	Windows key + D	Show the desktop
Ctrl + T	New browser tab	Ctrl + Shift + T	Reopen a closed tab
Windows key + Shift + S	Screenshot of part of the screen	Ctrl + scroll	Zoom in or out

On a Mac, use the **Command (⌘)** key in place of Ctrl for most of these.

Part 3 Email that looks professional

- **Your address**: make a simple, professional one, such as **firstname.lastname@gmail.com**. Keep “coolboy2009” for nothing.
- **Subject line**: say exactly what the email is about: “Application for Data Analysis course – Aisha Bello”.

- **Greeting and sign-off**: “Dear Mr Okafor,” … “Kind regards, Aisha Bello”. Use “Assalāmu ʿalaykum” where suitable.
- **Keep it short and clear**: who you are, what you need, by when. Use short paragraphs.
- **Attachments**: name files clearly, use PDF for documents you send, and mention the attachment in the email. Check it is attached before sending.
- **To, Cc and Bcc**: “To” is the main person; “Cc” keeps others informed; “Bcc” hides addresses (use it when emailing a group of people who do not know each other).
- **Read it once before sending**, and never write in ALL CAPITALS: it reads like shouting.

Example

Subject: Request for recommendation letter – Yusuf Adewale

Dear Mrs Ibrahim,

I hope you are well. I am applying to study Computer Science at the University of Lagos, and I would be grateful if you could write me a short recommendation letter. The deadline is 20 November. I have attached my CV and the university’s form.

Thank you for your time.

Kind regards, Yusuf Adewale (SS3B, 2025/2026)

Part 4 Documents

1. **Use headings** (Home › Styles › Heading 1, Heading 2) instead of just making text bigger. They create a neat structure and an automatic table of contents.
2. **One font, two sizes**: a clear font such as Calibri or Arial at 11–12 pt for text, larger for headings.
3. **Use lists and tables** for steps and data, not long paragraphs.
4. **Check spelling and grammar** (Review › Spelling), and read it aloud once.
5. **Insert page numbers** (Insert › Page Number) in anything longer than two pages.
6. **Save a PDF** to share or print (File › Save As › PDF), so it looks the same on every device.

In **Google Docs**, everything saves automatically, and you can share a document with a link and choose whether others can view, comment or edit. Use **Suggesting** mode to propose changes without overwriting someone else's work.

Part 5 Spreadsheets

A spreadsheet (Excel or Google Sheets) is a grid of **cells**, named by column letter and row number: **A1, B2, C10**. Spreadsheets are used for budgets, results, inventories and almost every kind of data work. Every formula starts with **=**.

Formula	What it does	Example
=SUM(B2:B10)	Adds a range of cells	Total sales for the week
=AVERAGE(B2:B10)	The mean of a range	Average test score
=MAX(B2:B10) / =MIN(B2:B10)	Highest / lowest value	Best and worst score
=COUNT(B2:B10)	How many cells have numbers	Number of students who sat a test
=IF(B2>=50,"Pass","Fail")	Checks a condition	Pass or fail for each student
=B2*C2	Multiply two cells	Price × quantity
=ROUND(B2,1)	Round to 1 decimal place	Neat averages

Try this

In column A, type five students' names; in column B, their scores. In B7 type **=AVERAGE(B2:B6)**. In C2 type **=IF(B2>=50,"Pass","Fail")** and drag the small square at the corner of the cell down to C6 to copy it. Select the names and scores and choose **Insert › Chart** to make a bar chart.

Part 6 Presentations

- **One idea per slide**, with a clear title that says the point: “Sales rose 20% in March”, not just “Sales”.
- **Few words**: no more than about six lines; you speak, the slide supports.
- **Big, clear pictures and charts**, and the same simple design on every slide.
- **Large text**: at least 24 pt, so the back of the room can read it.
- **Practise aloud** with the slides at least twice. Our guide Speak with Confidence explains how.

Part 7 Searching well, and using AI wisely

Search trick	Example	What it does
"Quotation marks"	"WAEC syllabus 2026"	Finds that exact phrase
site:	scholarship site:gov.ng	Searches only one website or domain
Minus sign	python -snake	Leaves out a word
filetype:	physics past questions filetype:pdf	Finds a type of file
Tools › Time	(in the search page)	Shows only recent results

Check your sources. Prefer official websites (JAMB, WAEC, universities, government), well-known organisations and named experts. Compare at least two sources for anything important, and be careful with screenshots and forwarded messages.

AI assistants can explain a topic, give you practice questions, or check your writing. Use them as a tutor, not a cheat: do your own work, check what they say against your textbook (they can be confidently wrong), never paste private information into them, and follow your school’s rules. Presenting AI-written work as your own is dishonest.

Part 8 Staying safe online

1. **Strong passwords**: long (at least 12 characters), unique for each account. A short sentence works well: **MyGoatEats3Mangoes!**
2. **Never reuse** your email password anywhere else. Consider a password manager to remember them for you.
3. **Turn on 2-step verification** for email, banking and social media, so a stolen password is not enough.
4. **Spot phishing**: messages that create panic ("your account will be closed"), ask for passwords or OTPs, or come from strange addresses. Banks never ask for your PIN or OTP.
5. **Update** your phone, computer and apps; updates fix security holes.
6. **Back up** important files in the cloud.
7. **Public computers**: always sign out, and never let the browser save your password.

Part 9 A 30-day practice plan

Week	Daily (30–45 minutes)	By the end of the week
1	Typing practice; organise your files and folders	Typing 20+ words a minute; a tidy folder system
2	Typing; create a professional email; write and format a one-page document	A neat CV in Docs or Word, saved as PDF
3	Typing; spreadsheets: formulas and a chart	A personal budget or results sheet with SUM, AVERAGE and IF
4	Typing; make a 6-slide presentation; set up 2-step verification	A short presentation delivered to family or friends

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. Which shortcut undoes your last action?

a) Ctrl + Z b) Ctrl + Y c) Ctrl + U d) Ctrl + P

2. Which file type is best for sending a document that must look the same everywhere?

a) .docx b) .pdf c) .txt d) .zip

3. Which formula finds the average of cells B2 to B10?

a) =SUM(B2:B10) b) =AVG(B2-B10) c) =AVERAGE(B2:B10) d) =MEAN B2:B10

4. You want to email 30 parents who do not know each other. You should put their addresses in:

a) To b) Cc c) Bcc d) The subject

5. **Which is the strongest password?**

   a) 123456 b) Aisha2009 c) password d) MyGoatEats3Mangoes!

6. **A message says your bank account will be blocked unless you send your OTP. You should:**

   a) Send it quickly b) Ignore it and report it c) Reply asking why d) Forward it to friends

7. **Which search finds only PDF files?**

   a) site:pdf b) "pdf" c) filetype:pdf d) -pdf

8. **Using an AI assistant honestly means:**

   a) Copying its answer as your own essay b) Using it to explain and check, then doing your own work c) Pasting private data into it d) Believing everything it says

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	a) Ctrl + Z	5	d) MyGoatEats3Mangoes!
2	b) .pdf	6	b) Ignore and report
3	c) =AVERAGE(B2:B10)	7	c) filetype:pdf
4	c) Bcc	8	b) Explain and check, do your own work

Free places to keep learning

- **Google Digital Skills for Africa** (learndigital.withgoogle.com) for digital and career skills.
- **typing.com** or **keybr.com** for typing.
- **Microsoft Learn** and **Google Workspace Learning Center** for Word, Excel, Docs and Sheets.
- **Khan Academy** for computing and much more.

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وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

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Small skills, big doors.

This free guide from the Himaayah Skills School teaches the everyday digital skills that school, university and work now expect, step by step.

- Using a computer and managing files
- Email that looks professional
- Documents, spreadsheets and slides
- Searching well, staying safe, and using AI wisely
- Shortcuts, a 30-day plan and a self-test

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